

and setting it aside for pizza night later in the week. On assembly-cooking days, I'll cook up more.) Use a biscuit cutter or the open end of a clean, empty soup can and continue to press the meat against the pan, cutting it into smaller pieces as you go. Most people stop at the large chunk stage, which doesn't take the savings to the level most folks are needing these days.

Keep going until your pieces of ground meat are more the size of large granules or imitation bacon bits. You'll then be free to explore using meat more as a flavor source rather than a mainstay. By embracing this, you'll be able to stretch your ground meats further than you may have considered possible.

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2. To dice is nice

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While you can certainly do this with any leftover roast meat when you've cooked a large batch for dinner, this is also a super-easy hack for precooked boneless meats you are able to snag for a good price. Dice the heck out of it from the very beginning, and put it into smaller packages for use in casseroles, soups, pasta salads, carbonara, and more.

In addition to precooked boneless hams, turkey hams, Spam, and large blocks of pressed ham loaf, consider pepperoni, precooked boneless turkey

breast, or even snagging some breaded chicken breast strips from the deli counter to dice up at home for a DIY crispy chicken southwest salad with corn and black beans.

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3. Accent ingredient

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You can create a tasty meal that places meat at center stage without making it the main ingredient. Add a few pieces of sliced steak to make a dinner salad. You get the full aromatherapy factor if you grill it at home, and can then thinly slice it diagonally for the full color variation. Want some more drama? Add a grainy spice rub prior to grilling for extra flavor and texture on the steak slices. Grilling a single marinated chicken breast and using the same dinner salad menu is also another way to feed more than one person from a single piece of meat.

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4. Coupons can apply

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Grant you, for larger portions of fresh cuts, these are rare and usually require the purchase of another item. However, when it comes to canned and presliced meats, coupons abound. Combined with a buy-one-get-one-free offer on double coupon week, you can score big. Another great time to try is during the summer when hot dogs go on sale.